

FOR FIRST-TIME & SELF-PUBLISHING AUTHORS

The Author's Scam-Proof & Real-Cost Checklist

*Know the warning signs before you sign anything — and
know exactly what publishing your book should really cost.*

01

15-POINT RED FLAG CHECKLIST
FOR SPOTTING PREDATORY
PUBLISHING COMPANIES

02

REAL-WORLD COST BENCHMARKS
FOR EDITING, DESIGN,
FORMATTING & MARKETING

You Wrote the Book. Don't Let the Wrong Deal Undo It.

"I lost three months and my savings to a company that promised a bestseller and delivered nothing." — a story we hear more often than we'd like.

The self-publishing industry has no gatekeeper. Anyone can build a website, call themselves a "publisher," and take payment from an author who just wants to see their name on a cover. Most are legitimate. Some are not. This guide gives you two tools to protect yourself and your budget — whether you work with Collingwood Press, another publisher, or go fully independent.

\$2K–\$25K+

The realistic range authors spend on professional self-publishing, depending on scope. Anyone quoting far outside this range deserves a closer look.

15

Warning signs covered in this checklist, grouped into contracts & money, communication, and promises & claims.

6

Core services benchmarked with real cost ranges: editing, cover design, formatting, ISBN, distribution, and marketing.

How to Use This Guide

1

Before signing with *any* publishing company or freelancer, run their pitch, quote, and contract through the Part 1 checklist. Any single checked box is worth pausing on. Three or more is a serious concern.

2

Compare their quote against the Part 2 cost benchmarks. This tells you whether you're looking at a fair price, a lowball that will cut corners, or a markup that's paying for a sales team, not your book.

3

Use the self-assessment on page 6 to decide whether you're ready to move forward, need more information, or should walk away from a specific offer.

15 Red Flags of a Predatory Publisher

Check every box that applies to a company, contract, or offer you're evaluating. These are patterns reported by authors who lost money, rights, or months of time — not hypotheticals.

MONEY & CONTRACTS

- ☐ **Full payment demanded upfront, with no milestone-based structure.**
Legitimate publishing services break payment into stages tied to actual deliverables (edit complete, cover approved, files delivered).
 - ☐ **The contract is vague about what you'll actually receive.**
"Full editing" or "marketing package" with no defined scope, number of rounds, or timeline is a red flag, not a feature.
 - ☐ **The company claims any ownership or long-term rights to your manuscript.**
You should retain full copyright, royalties, and creative control. Any clause that says otherwise needs a lawyer's eyes before you sign.
 - ☐ **Pricing changes dramatically once you show interest.**
A quote that jumps after a "limited time" sales call is a pressure tactic, not a real discount.
 - ☐ **No itemized breakdown of what you're paying for.**
One flat number with no line items makes it impossible to know if you're overpaying for any single service.
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COMMUNICATION & PROCESS

- ☐ **You can't get a straight answer to a direct question.**
Deflection, over-promising, or "let's discuss on a call" instead of a written answer is a stalling tactic.
 - ☐ **No named, reachable point of contact once payment is made.**
If the friendly sales rep disappears the moment the contract is signed, that's the pattern authors report most before a project goes dark.
 - ☐ **High-pressure, time-limited sales tactics.**
"This price is only good today" is a sales script. Real publishing decisions don't need to be made in the next hour.
 - ☐ **Heavy upselling before the first deliverable is even finished.**
Being pitched five additional "premium" services before your edit is done suggests revenue, not your book, is the priority.
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PROMISES & CLAIMS

- ☐ **A guarantee of bestseller status, a movie deal, or a specific sales number.**
No legitimate publisher can guarantee sales. Anyone who does is selling a fantasy, not a service.
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Red Flags, Continued

PROMISES & CLAIMS (CONT.)

☐ **Testimonials that can't be verified anywhere outside their own website.**

Check for independent reviews on Trustpilot, BBB, or Reviews.io — not just quotes on the sales page.

☐ **"We'll get you into bookstores" with no explanation of how.**

Physical shelf placement requires wholesale distribution relationships. Ask which distributor they use and how returns are handled.

☐ **Marketing described only in vague terms like "we'll promote your book everywhere."**

Ask for specifics: which platforms, what budget, what reporting you'll receive, and what "success" is measured against.

☐ **Reluctance to explain the difference between their packages in writing.**

If you can't get a side-by-side comparison of what each tier includes, you can't make an informed decision.

☐ **No clear return policy or plan if you're unhappy with a deliverable.**

Ask what happens if you reject the first cover design or edit — the answer tells you everything about how they'll treat you after payment.

Scoring yourself: 0 boxes checked — proceed with normal diligence. 1–2 boxes — ask direct written questions before paying anything. 3+ boxes — strongly reconsider, or ask a trusted, unaffiliated author or editor to review the contract with you before you sign.

A NOTE ON THIS LIST

None of these signs alone proves bad intent — small or new companies sometimes have imperfect processes for innocent reasons. But when several of these stack together, they describe a consistent, well-documented pattern that authors have reported losing money to. Trust the pattern, not the pitch.

What Publishing Your Book Should Actually Cost

General industry ranges for a full-length manuscript (60,000–90,000 words), sourced from typical freelance and agency market rates. Use these to sanity-check any quote — from Collingwood Press or anyone else.

SERVICE	TYPICAL RANGE	WHAT AFFECTS THE PRICE
Editing	\$800–\$5,000+	Copy editing (lightest touch) to full developmental editing (structure, plot, pacing). Priced per word or per hour; genre and manuscript condition matter.
Cover Design	\$300–\$2,000	Template-based custom covers sit at the low end; fully original illustrated art or hand-lettered typography sits at the high end.
Interior Formatting	\$150–\$800	Ebook-only formatting is cheapest; print formatting (paperback + hardcover, InDesign layout) costs more due to trim size and margin work.
ISBN & Registration	\$0–\$125	Free if self-assigned through some regional agencies; ranges based on country and whether you need separate ISBNs per format.
Global Distribution	\$0–\$500	Many retailers (Amazon KDP, IngramSpark) charge no setup fee; paid tiers add wider wholesale and library distribution.
Marketing & Launch	\$500–\$6,000+	Depends heavily on scope: organic social setup vs. paid ad campaigns, review outreach, and press coverage.

IF A QUOTE IS FAR BELOW THIS RANGE

Ask what's being cut. Extremely low prices usually mean a single editing pass instead of multiple rounds, template covers with no customization, or AI-generated work with no human review.

IF A QUOTE IS FAR ABOVE THIS RANGE

Ask exactly what's included at each price point. High prices aren't automatically wrong, but they should map to a clearly itemized scope, not a vague "premium" label.

Are You Ready to Say Yes?

Before you sign with any publishing partner — Collingwood Press included — you should be able to answer these plainly.

You're Ready When...

- You have a written, itemized breakdown of every service and cost.
- You know exactly who your point of contact is after you pay.
- The contract explicitly confirms you retain full rights and royalties.
- You've checked at least one independent review source (BBB, Trustpilot, Reviews.io).
- You understand the realistic timeline, not just an optimistic one.

You Need More Information When...

- Any pricing feels rushed, bundled, or hard to break down.
- You've been shown testimonials but haven't verified them independently.
- You're not clear on what happens if you're unhappy with a deliverable.
- Marketing promises are described in outcomes ("bestseller") rather than actions (specific channels, specific spend).

0 FLAGS

Proceed with a normal, healthy level of due diligence. Ask your questions and move forward with confidence.

1–2 FLAGS

Get clear, written answers before paying anything. A trustworthy company will welcome the questions.

3+ FLAGS

Pause. Get a second opinion from an unaffiliated author, editor, or the resources above before signing.

Publishing your book is a big decision, but it doesn't have to be a scary one. The right partner will welcome every question on this page — not avoid them.

Why Authors Choose Collingwood Press

You don't have to take our word for any of this — every claim below is something you can independently verify before you ever pay us a dollar.



BBB Accredited Business

Collingwood Press holds active Better Business Bureau accreditation — a status that requires meeting the BBB's standards for truthful advertising, transparency, and responsiveness to customer complaints. You can look up our exact rating and file history directly on bbb.org before signing anything, which is more than most publishing companies will let you do.

Trustpilot

Verified client reviews

Reviews.io

Independent ratings

G2

Listed seller profile

1,500+ Authors Published

From debut writers to established authors across fiction, nonfiction, and memoir — a track record you can cross-check against real, verifiable titles.

Full Rights, Every Time

You retain 100% of your copyright, royalties, and creative control before, during, and after the project. It's written into every contract, not just promised on a call.

A Named Human, Not a Ticket Number

Every author is assigned a dedicated project manager who is reachable by phone throughout the entire process — not just during the sales conversation.

Global Distribution Network

Real distribution relationships across Amazon, Apple Books, Kobo, IngramSpark, Barnes & Noble, and more — the same names listed in this guide's cost benchmarks.

Transparent, Itemized Pricing

Every quote breaks down exactly what you're paying for — editing, design, formatting, and marketing priced separately, never bundled into one unexplained number.

End-to-End Capability

Ghostwriting, editing, cover design, formatting, ISBN and distribution, marketing, and audiobook production — one accountable team instead of a chain of freelancers.

The takeaway: everything on this page is something a predatory publisher, by definition, can't offer — verifiable accreditation, named accountability, and a paper trail you can check before you commit.

A WORD FROM COLLINGWOOD PRESS

You Don't Have to Navigate This Alone.

We built this checklist because we've spoken to too many authors who got burned before they ever found us. Whether or not you ever work with Collingwood Press, we'd rather you publish safely than not at all.

1 Transparent, itemized pricing.

Every quote we give breaks down exactly what you're paying for — no bundled mystery packages.

2 You keep every right to your work.

Full copyright, full royalties, full control — before, during, and after we work together. Not negotiable.

3 A named human, not a ticket number.

Your project manager is reachable by phone throughout your entire project, not just before you sign.

NEXT STEP

Get a Free, No-Obligation Manuscript Review

A real editor reads your work and gives direct feedback within 5–7 days — no automated reports, no pressure to buy anything.

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